



Daily care for your condition - Organ transplant

This handout tells you what you need to do to care for your organ transplant and work with your doctor to stay healthy.



Follow your self-care plan.

- The self-care plan is a list of what you need to do every day to manage your care after the transplant.
- It tells you the signs that your condition is getting worse and when to take action right away.
- Ask your doctor or nurse if there are things you do not understand.
- Make and keep all doctor visits.



Take your medicine as your doctor told you.

- Take your medicines the right way after your transplant.
 - Do not take all your medicines at one time. The doses are spread out to keep the right levels in your body.
 - Tell your doctor or transplant team if you miss a dose.
 - Ask the transplant team before taking vitamins, herbs, or medicines you buy at the store.
- Know why you take each medicine.
- Know the medicine side effects to watch out for.
- Know what to do if you miss a dose.
- Keep a list of all the medicine you take to show your doctor.
- Get the follow-up tests that your doctor orders.



Do health checks at home.

- You may need to check your blood pressure every day.
 - Wait 30 minutes after exercise before you take your blood pressure.
 - Take your blood pressure in the same arm each time.
 - Write down your blood pressure reading in a diary to show your doctor.
- Follow a plan if your blood pressure is too high or low. Seek medical care right away if:
 - It goes higher than _____ / _____.
 - It goes lower than _____ / _____.
- Know your target blood pressure range. Work to keep it at this level.
 - The top number (systolic) can range from _____ to _____.
 - The bottom number (diastolic) can range from _____ to _____.
- You may need to check your heart rate every day.
 - Sit quietly for 10 minutes before you start.
 - Place 2 fingers lightly on the artery on the inside of your wrist. Do not use your thumb.
 - Using a clock or watch with a second hand, count the beats you feel for 60 seconds.
 - Write down your heart rate in a diary to show your doctor.
- Know your target heart rate range.
 - It is too high when it is _____.
 - It is too low when it is _____.
 - Take steps to keep your heart rate under control.
 - Write down your heart rate in a diary to show your doctor.

- You may need to weigh yourself every day.
- Take your temperature every day. Keep a diary of your temperatures to show your doctor.
- Bring a diary of your health checks to your doctor visits.



Follow the eating plan as your doctor told you.

- You should eat a balance of healthy foods after a transplant.
 - Lean protein, like chicken (no skin), tofu, or eggs
 - Fiber, like whole grain cereals, vegetables, and fruits to keep stools from getting too hard (constipation)
 - Limit foods with a lot of fat, cholesterol, salt (sodium), or sugar.
 - Take a multivitamin, if your doctor says it is OK.
 - Avoid alcohol, like beer, wine, hard liquor, and mixed drinks.
 - You may not be able to drink grapefruit juice with certain medicines. Ask your doctor or pharmacist if there are things you should not eat or drink.
- Keep from catching or spreading germs from food.
 - Wash hands before and after handling and eating food.
 - Wash fruits and vegetables with water before eating.
 - Only eat chicken, pork, and beef when cooked all the way through.
 - Do not eat food that was left at room temperature for more than 2 hours.
- Avoid foods that could make you sick, such as:
 - Raw or undercooked meat, eggs, and fish
 - Unpasteurized milk or cheese (like feta, brie, camembert, Roquefort, and Mexican soft cheese)
 - Raw sprouts, like bean and alfalfa

- Talk to your doctor about what you should eat.
 - Calorie needs are based on my activity level and the need to gain or lose weight.
 - I should eat _____ calories a day.



Take steps for a healthy lifestyle.

- Keep active and exercise.
 - Get extra rest while you are healing. Try to be a little more active each day. Rest when you feel you need to.
 - Talk to your doctor about what exercise is best for you and make it part of your day.
 - Do not drive or return to work until your doctor says it is OK.
- Prevent blood clots in your legs.
 - Keep your legs propped up while lying down.
 - Avoid sitting for long periods of time. If you do, stretch your legs as much as you can. Do not cross your legs while sitting.
 - Do not wear socks with tight bands that leave marks on your legs.
 - Wear compression stockings every day if your doctor told you to.
 - Take blood thinner medicine if your doctor orders it.
- Get a medical ID bracelet, necklace, or card for your wallet that says you had a transplant. Keep it with you at all times.
- Lose weight if you are overweight.
- Learn healthy ways to manage stress.
- Do not smoke.
- Do not drink alcohol.
- Do not use drugs or misuse medicine.

- Get your shots (vaccines) each year, like the flu shot.



Know the signs that your condition is getting worse.

- Know when to call for emergency help.
 - You think you are having a heart attack or stroke.
 - You have very bad breathing problems.
 - You have any signs of a blood clot in your leg.
- Know when to call your doctor or transplant team.
 - See the **When to get help - Organ transplant** handout.

This information is general in nature and may not apply to you or your condition. Talk to your doctor or nurse about how to best use this information and how to take care of your medical condition. Be sure to ask your doctor or nurse any questions you might have. This information sheet is not intended to provide or replace professional medical advice, diagnosis, or treatment.

Patient or Caregiver:

Signature: _____ Date: _____

Nurse:

Signature: _____ Date: _____